PORTFOLIO CASE STUDY

Strategic Investment Readiness & Advisory Framework

Sector: Agritech & Digital Agriculture
Region: Central Africa
Engagement: SME Growth, Investment Readiness & Impact Mentorship

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CONFIDENTIALITY & ANONYMIZATION NOTE

This case study is a portfolio-ready adaptation of a consulting engagement. Client names, exact financial figures, and sensitive due diligence findings have been anonymized or generalized to protect client confidentiality while demonstrating advisory methodology and strategic outcomes.

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PROJECT TITLE

Strategic Investment Readiness and Impact Measurement Framework for a Central African Agritech Platform

CLIENT OVERVIEW

The client is an emerging agritech enterprise operating in Central Africa. The company provides soil intelligence and digital advisory services to smallholder farmers, utilizing a cooperative-led distribution model. Their platform integrates IoT field telemetry, AI-driven agronomic recommendations, and digital farm records. The organization had successfully built a field presence and a live technology platform but required strategic guidance to transition from a minimum viable product (MVP) to an enterprise-ready, investment-grade business.

CHALLENGE

The client was seeking to secure significant institutional debt financing to scale their hardware deployment and deepen their field operations. However, during the preliminary review of their investment materials, several structural, strategic, and financial challenges emerged that threatened their funding eligibility.

The primary challenges included:

- **Investment Readiness:** The organization lacked a cohesive, evidence-based narrative to present to institutional lenders. Their financial models required stress-testing against their audited historical performance.
- **Strategic Coherence:** The diligence materials contained conflicting strategic directions, creating confusion regarding the core business model and raising governance concerns.
- **Customer Verification:** While the client claimed a substantial active farmer network, the underlying data had not been reconciled against physical contracts, invoices, and bank/mobile-money receipts, representing a major due diligence gap.
- **Technology Validation:** The IoT hardware lacked independent laboratory validation against established soil science standards, creating a technical risk barrier to scaled manufacturing.
- **Impact Measurement:** The organization lacked a formal Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) framework, making it difficult to substantiate their social impact and agricultural yield claims to impact-focused funders.

MY ROLE

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I was engaged as a strategic advisor to the executive leadership (CEO and CTO). My mandate was to diagnose the investment readiness gaps, pressure-test the financial and operational models, and provide a structured, actionable roadmap to transition the company from an operational MVP to a fundable enterprise.

SCOPE OF WORK

- **Investment Readiness Assessment:** Reviewed all due diligence documents, financial models, and pitch materials to identify critical red flags and structural gaps.
- **Financial Sustainability Review:** Analyzed the historical audited financials against the proposed debt facility to assess debt service coverage and repayment viability.
- **Business Model Analysis:** Evaluated the unit economics of the cooperative-led hardware and subscription model.
- **Due Diligence Support:** Designed the framework for customer data reconciliation and hardware validation protocols.
- **Governance Review:** Assessed corporate structuring and internal alignment between leadership and documentation.
- **MEL Framework Design:** Developed a comprehensive Theory of Change, Logical Framework, and KPI dashboard to track operational and impact metrics.
- **Strategic Roadmap Development:** Created an 8-week implementation plan to close the identified diligence gaps and prepare for lender engagement.

METHODOLOGY

To deliver value, I applied a structured, mixed-methods consulting approach:

- **Quantitative Financial Analysis:** I reconstructed the client's debt schedule, applying amortization formulas and interest capitalization rules to assess debt service coverage ratios (DSCR) against historical gross operating surpluses.
- **Data Validation & Verification:** I mapped the client's four-tier pricing structure to their audited revenue lines to identify discrepancies, then designed a reconciliation pipeline (Contract → Invoice → Receipt → Bank Trace) to verify the customer base.
- **Strategic & Governance Analysis:** I conducted a cross-document analysis to identify contradictory claims across the investment memo, corporate profile, and project teasers. I mapped the corporate entity structure to identify potential legal bottlenecks prior to facility signing.
- **MEL Framework Development:** I utilized participatory workshop techniques to design a Theory of Change, establishing clear causal pathways from project inputs to long-term impact. I then translated this into a Logical Framework with SMART indicators.
- **Business Intelligence:** I designed the architecture for an executive KPI dashboard, defining metrics for active farmers, collection rates, unit economics (CAC/LTV), and device uptime.

KEY FINDINGS

My assessment surfaced critical insights that fundamentally shifted the client's fundraising strategy:

1. **Debt Capacity Mismatch:** The audited business demonstrated solid historical revenue growth and profitability. However, the proposed debt facility's annual service requirements vastly exceeded the current operating cash flow and gross operating surplus, meaning repayment relied entirely on an unproven, aggressive scaling trajectory.
2. **Customer Base Verification:** The stated active customer count was not fully reconciled to actual cash collections. The organization was treating registered or contracted users as equivalent to fully activated, paying users, which presented a significant risk to the lender.
3. **Strategic Divergence:** The diligence pack contained two entirely different business models. The core investment memo focused on a high-tech soil intelligence platform, while supplementary documents detailed a completely separate, highly speculative industrial processing and carbon-credit venture. This contradiction severely undermined the organization's credibility.
4. **Technical Debt:** The hardware engineering team had not yet secured third-party validation for their sensor accuracy, which acted as a hard gate against scaling hardware manufacturing and deployment.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the findings, I presented the executive team with a prioritized, five-point strategic pivot:

1. **Strategic Consolidation:** Immediately remove all materials related to the speculative processing venture. Focus 100% of the investment narrative on the core, audited soil intelligence platform.
2. **Data Reconciliation & Verification:** Halt all fundraising activities until a 100% reconciliation of the customer base against financial receipts is completed. Rebuild the financial model based *only* on verified, collectible recurring revenue.
3. **Corporate Governance Alignment:** Resolve the corporate entity structure immediately. Execute board resolutions and secure legal confirmation of the specific borrowing entity before approaching lenders.
4. **Technology Validation:** Commission an independent laboratory comparison of the IoT hardware against accredited soil testing methods to unlock the manufacturing budget and satisfy technical due diligence.

5. **Evidence-Based Impact:** Implement the newly designed MEL framework to transition from anecdotal impact claims to rigorous, data-backed evidence of farmer yield improvements and income growth.

OUTCOMES

By applying this rigorous consulting framework, the engagement delivered immediate and lasting value to the client:

- **Strengthened Investment Readiness:** The client gained a clear, uncompromised understanding of the exact diligence gates they must pass to secure funding.
- **Improved Strategic Clarity:** The leadership team aligned around a single, fundable core business model, eliminating the credibility risk posed by conflicting documents.
- **Enhanced Governance Readiness:** The organization was equipped with a clear legal and operational checklist to resolve entity confusion and formalize board-level oversight.
- **Actionable Roadmap:** The delivery of an 8-week implementation plan provided the CTO and CEO with a step-by-step guide to closing the diligence gaps.
- **Robust Monitoring Systems:** The newly designed MEL framework and KPI dashboard enabled the organization to track cohort retention, unit economics, and agricultural impact with institutional-grade precision.

SKILLS DEMONSTRATED

- **Business Advisory:** Providing executive-level strategic counsel to founders.
- **Investment Readiness & Due Diligence:** Auditing financial models, corporate structures, and pitch decks against institutional standards.
- **Financial Analysis:** Evaluating DSCR, amortization schedules, and unit economics (CAC, LTV).
- **Data Analytics:** Schema mapping, revenue reconciliation, and data validation.
- **Monitoring, Evaluation & Learning (MEL):** Designing Theories of Change, Logical Frameworks, and KPI dashboards.
- **Risk Assessment:** Identifying strategic, technical, and financial red flags.
- **SME Development & Agritech Advisory:** Understanding the unique challenges of scaling hardware and software in emerging markets.
- **Business Intelligence:** Designing data pipelines and executive reporting dashboards.

TOOLS AND FRAMEWORKS USED

- Financial Modeling (Debt Service Coverage, Break-even Analysis)
- Strategic Planning (SWOT, Gap Analysis)
- Due Diligence Frameworks
- Theory of Change & Logical Frameworks
- Risk Management Matrices
- KPI Design & Impact Measurement
- Business Intelligence Dashboard Design
- Advanced Excel & Data Visualization Concepts

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Engaged as a strategic mentor for a Central African agritech platform scaling IoT and AI-driven soil intelligence. Conducted a comprehensive investment readiness assessment, auditing financial models, corporate governance, and technical validation protocols. Discovered critical debt-servicing gaps and strategic inconsistencies within the diligence materials. Formulated a strategic pivot to consolidate the business model, designed a data reconciliation pipeline to verify customer revenue, and developed a rigorous Theory of Change and KPI dashboard. Delivered an 8-week strategic roadmap that successfully positioned the founders to close institutional diligence gaps and establish a credible path to funding.